

mind. Obviously, if your son is studying in another city or overseas he will need one. Kids wanting to play games need a desktop. And a desktop will always have faster hardware, given the same price as a notebook. So if you've read this and still feel you need one, you now need to decide what sort of notebook you need.

If you are such a person who wants something compact with very good battery I have only one suggestion really – Acer's Timeline 3810T. I came across this model in a Tata Croma near my place and remember nearly everyone in our Test Centre going gaga about the product. It's got an Intel SU3500 CPU, which is pretty basic, but this doesn't matter for office automation work and mails. Battery backup is very good owing to the low-power components. And the notebook is a stunner with its gun-grey metal body. It's pretty lightweight and slim and feels sturdy. The keypad is also quite comfortable. The price is around Rs. 31,999, and I noticed Acer bundling an external DVD writer within this price tag. I reckon 32,000 bucks is a sweet price for this notebook and anyone looking for something portable yet functional with classy looks will be well served. The 3810T is perfect for businessmen and executives on the move, such people don't need much performance but just to be connected, which this notebook will more than fulfil.

For someone looking at a desktop replacement notebook, I recommend Acer's Aspire 5738G. It's priced at Rs. 40,000 (39,999 actually), and makes a sweet deal for the price. The screen is also pretty big at 15.6-inches and this is a plus for home users who will also watch movies. You can hook it up to a large screen TV, as it has HDMI. What I like is the presence of a good GPU in a sub-Rs. 50,000 notebook.

Unless, you are going to be watching Blu-ray or HD content on your notebook, or gaming, or using 3D animation packages or even image editing, there is hardly any need of a discrete GPU. Don't be attracted to a notebook just because it says "GeForce Go" or "ATi Mobility", I've seen people who need a notebook just to surf end up buying one with a discrete video solution just because somebody recommended one. If you do want to play the odd game or watch HD content, you may want to check out something in the range of the GeForce GT 130 or the ATi Mobility 4350 – these are pretty powerful notebook solutions.

I came across a couple of high-end Sony Z series notebooks. Touted as their business class solutions, these supposedly have carbon fibre used in their construction and are suitably compact and lightweight. Build quality seems exemplary and one model I saw even had an SSD as storage but I have a few concerns. For one, the resolution is 1600 x 900 pixels. This is too big for a tiny